UNQUALIFIED FAILURE

FTII AGITATION, 2015

Pune

46TH ANNIVERSARY
YOUTH UPRISINGS

Though Chauhan took charge in January 2016, he had a short tenure—just 14 months—which was not extended after it expired

Three days after the Centre announced that BJP member Gajendra Chauhan would be the new chairman of the Pune-based Film and Television Institute of India (FTII), students began a protest on June 9, 2015 that would continue for 139 days—among the longest in the history of an institution that has seen many student agitations. Protesters cited Chauhan's lack of credentials, with some members of the film fraternity too supporting their strike. Many students faced disciplinary action—among them, Payal Kapadia, who went on to make a documentary inspired by the protest titled *A Night of Knowing Nothing* and had her scholarship grant cut. (Her film would go on to win a prize at the Cannes Film Festival in 2021.) On August 3, some 80 students hit the streets of New Delhi, seeking a dialogue with the information and broadcasting ministry on the issue.

The strike was called off on October 28. Though Chauhan took charge on January 7, 2016, he had a short tenure—one year and two months. The central government has also made a change to the admission process now, requiring students to sign an affidavit that makes it more difficult to protest. ■

– Suhani Singh

A MATTER OF DEGREE Political appointments to educational institutions should consider a candidate's actual qualifications, not just whether they have worked in a particular sector

CHANDRADEEP KUMAR



▲ FTII students protest against Chauhan's appointment in Delhi, Aug. 3, 2013